

Exa

AI Search Infrastructure · Search API for AI Agents · San Francisco (founded 2021, Y Combinator) · Private (\$2.2B; \$250M Series C, May 2026)

Exa, the search engine built for AI agents, announced a \$250M Series C led by Andreessen Horowitz at a \$2.2B valuation on 20 May 2026, more than tripling the \$700M Benchmark set in September. It powers search for Cursor, Cognition and HubSpot and ships as a native Claude connector.

72
OPPORTUNITY / 100

TIMING WINDOW

HOT

SERIES

F1

RECOMMENDED TEAM

Atlassian
Williams Racing

ACTION HORIZON

6-10 WKS

THE CASE

On 20 May Exa announced a \$250M Series C led by Andreessen Horowitz at a \$2.2B valuation, confirmed by Bloomberg the same day. It follows an \$85M Series B led by Benchmark at \$700M in September 2025 and a \$22M Series A led by Lightspeed in July 2024. Exa says more than 5,000 companies and 400,000 developers use its search API, Cursor, Cognition and HubSpot among them. The money funds next-generation models, infrastructure for hundreds of thousands of searches a second, and a go-to-market build-out under Marcus Holm, joining as CRO from LaunchDarkly.

AI brands have moved onto the grid quickly: Claude races on the Williams, Cognition joined Aston Martin Aramco, Meta AI sits at Mercedes and TWG AI at Cadillac. Exa is the search layer beneath those agents, and the companies it positions against are already on cars, Google Cloud at McLaren and Microsoft at Mercedes and Alpine. A challenger with a \$250M war chest and a new revenue chief has a story to tell against them.

WHY NOW

The round was announced on 20 May; a first sports partnership is a decision for the quarter after a raise, when a new CRO is setting the brand budget. Monaco GP (7 June) and the British GP (5 July) fall inside the window, and 2027 rosters close in the autumn.

PROOF POINTS — EVERY FIGURE VERIFIED TO A PRIMARY SOURCE (SEE P.2)

\$250M

\$250M Series C led by Andreessen Horowitz at a \$2.2B valuation, announced 20 May 2026 (Exa blog; Bloomberg)

\$85M

Andreessen Horowitz (lead, Series C); Benchmark led the \$85M Series B at \$700M in September 2025; Lightspee...

GRID FIT — CATEGORY-WHITESPACE CHECK ACROSS THE F1 GRID (SPONSOR TABLE; 49 OF 346 PARTNER ROWS CATEGORISED)

Atlassian Williams Racing ♦ RECOMMENDED	OPEN	no rival in this category lane
McLaren Mastercard F1 Team	TAKEN	Dell Technologies
Aston Martin Aramco F1 Team	TAKEN	NetApp
Mercedes-AMG Petronas F1 Team	OPEN	no rival in this category lane

BOTTOM LINE

A \$250M round at \$2.2B, a new revenue chief with a go-to-market mandate, and a native connection to the Claude programme already on the Williams give Exa the budget, the motive and a warm path. The search lane at Williams is open, and Monaco and the British GP sit inside the window.

WHY ATLASSIAN WILLIAMS RACING

Williams runs the most software-native roster on the grid: Atlassian as title partner, VAST Data for the data platform, Keeper for identity, Airia and Brillio, and since February Claude as Official Thinking Partner inside engineering and strategy. No search or retrieval partner sits on the car. Exa is a native Claude connector, so the introduction runs through a partnership Williams already trusts, and the product plugs into a workflow the team already uses.

VALUE TO ATLASSIAN WILLIAMS RACING — MODE A (TECH IN THE CAR / CHAMPIONSHIP)

MODE A - operational. Williams engineers, strategists and commercial staff already work with Claude; Exa gives those agents live web retrieval: regulation and technical-directive monitoring, supplier and parts discovery, rival upgrade tracking from open sources, and media and prospect research through Websets. It is a lighter workstream than compute. In return: Official AI Search Partner designation, livery presence and British GP hospitality for Exa's developer audience.

DEAL ARCHITECTURE

Entry as Official AI Search Partner. **THREE YEARS**, 2027-2029, covering the go-to-market build-out and any listing window. Estimated \$2-4M a year, part-payable in API credits for the team's agents. Scope: sidepod or halo placement, naming of the team's research-agent stack, British GP hospitality, developer content with the Claude programme.

PRIMARY DECISION-MAKER

Will Bryk

CO-FOUNDER & CEO, EXA · **VERIFIED**

Bryk co-founded Exa in 2021 with Jeff Wang, a Harvard classmate, and CTO Dan McArdle, and fronts every raise; a first sports partnership is his call. Path: Marcus Holm, incoming CRO, owns go-to-market; Jeff Wang oversees finance. No CMO, CFO or COO is listed.

OPENING ANGLE

Lead with the Claude connection.

“Will, Exa is already a Claude connector and Claude already races on the Williams. Cognition took its seat at Aston Martin in its breakout year; the search lane at Williams is open. 25 minutes before Monaco to see the numbers?”

SCORE COMPOSITION

TIMING 17 / 20 Round announced 20 May; Monaco and the British GP inside the window.	CAPACITY 16 / 20 \$250M raise at \$2.2B; \$357M across three rounds; no revenue disclosed.	BRAND FIT 13 / 20 Developer API brand; low consumer reach, strong AI narrative.	URGENCY 12 / 20 No listing signal; the CRO hire is the brand-build trigger.	OPS FIT 14 / 20 MODE A: live retrieval for agents Williams already runs.
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RISKS & COUNTERS

THIN WORKSTREAM Web retrieval for research agents is real but modest next to a compute or data partner; the team may see a logo, not a tool. **Counter:** Scope a 90-day pilot inside the Claude workflow before the commercial term; size part of the fee in API credits.

CROWDED TECHNOLOGY TIER Williams already carries Claude, VAST, Keeper, Airia and Brillio; a further technology name risks second billing. **Counter:** Take a defined Official AI Search Partner category with its own on-car placement.

SOURCES — 16 OF 16 LOAD-BEARING CLAIMS VERIFIED

- https://exa.ai/blog/announcing-series-c
- https://claude.com/connectors/exa
- https://siliconangle.com/2025/09/03/nvidia-backs-85m-round-ai-search-startup-exa/